Week 24

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 6 · LESSON 4

Authority

BIG IDEA

If the Bible is accurate, historical and fulfills prophecy, then it has authority over our lives, so now what? This lesson helps students answer common objections and move toward appreciating, reading and following God's Word.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. This lesson invites a response: if the Bible is everything the past weeks have shown, it has authority over our lives. Now what?
2. Choose a student changed by these weeks as storyteller; a peer's conviction can land harder than an adult's. Otherwise, invite a graduate now in college.
3. Objection one: men wrote the Bible. Students ask how Matthew could record Jesus' words exactly when most of us can't quote a sermon we just heard.
4. One way to answer: if Jesus is fully man and fully God, God can also use human writers to record His words with complete accuracy.
5. Objection two: the Bible is just people's ideas about God. But God showed us who He really is in Jesus, so Scripture is accurate about God, not mere opinion.
6. Aim for students to appreciate the Bible more, read it more and follow it better, and to talk about it intelligently with friends and in college.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Do I live as though the Bible has authority over my life, or only over what I teach?
2. When did I last read Scripture just to listen, not to prepare a lesson?
3. Which student might be ready to share how these weeks have changed them?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. After these four weeks, what conclusion are you coming to about the Bible?
2. How would you answer someone who says the Bible can't be God's Word because people wrote it?
3. What makes it hard to treat the Bible as having authority over your life?
4. What would help you read the Bible more this month?
5. If a friend questioned the Bible, what from these weeks would you share with them?

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WEEK 24 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

What this lesson asks

0:05 Lesson number four: authority. This lesson is basically a response. It's invoking a response from your students of this: if the Bible is all that we've said the Bible is so far, then now what? Because the Bible clearly has something to say that's really, really important, and it has some authority over our lives. So now what?

Choosing the storyteller

0:40 So let's start with the storyteller. The storyteller could be — and this week I would suggest it be — a student. I would ask your students who has been greatly impacted over the last couple of weeks. I would ask them, hey, who has really just had their mind completely blown and needs to get it off their chest about what this means, because now they're going to have a changed life, moving in the direction that God desires.

1:10 Maybe that's in connection with a retreat, or with a specific moment in their life. But if you've got a student like that, then I would highly encourage you to use that, because what happens in these kinds of moments is that it's really easy for an adult to say, this book is important, you should follow it. Well, they're still learning this book, as many of us are as well. And it's hard for them to really grasp: okay, what parts do I follow, and how do I follow, and what's literal and what's not?

1:42 There are just so many other things here that they often look at us adults and think, yeah, but you've got it figured out and you can do it. I don't need that right now. I'm young and I can do what I want. When I'm your age, maybe I'll do that. I get that it's important, and I'll get there. It's more powerful if one of their peers stands up and declares, based on the evidence, based on what we've studied, based on the conviction of the Holy Spirit: I believe this book to be authoritative, and I'm going to respond in that way and make sure my life is headed down the path that God wants it to go. That's a powerful, powerful statement, and a powerful storyteller, if they can recall how that happened.

2:28 And you might have other students, and maybe that is happening to them and they either don't realize it or aren't willing to speak up about it. That might conjure up some other feelings from some other students and give you a little bit of a gauge of where you're at. If you don't have a student in that space, then I would suggest that maybe you have a graduate — someone who has gone through your program and is now in college. Now that things are kind of rolling along and they've been in college for a little bit of time, maybe they're starting to experience some things, maybe they're starting to see the importance of what's in here, especially with some of the contradictions they may be hearing on the college campus. Have them come in and talk about the Bible's authority and fill that storyteller role.

The objections you'll hear

3:15 Okay, so we say it all the time and we hear it all the time, right? The Bible is the word of God. And what we're saying is that the Bible is inspired. The Bible is infallible. The Bible is the word of God. Everything in it is absolutely true. Therefore, it must be authoritative, right? But what students will often struggle with, and what you'll hear in terms of objections, is this: that the Bible was written by men.

3:45 Wait a minute, how can the Bible be authoritative? And yeah, okay, sure, it can be historical, and okay, yeah, it can fulfill prophecy, and okay, it can be completely accurate in some kind of strange way. But how can it be so authoritative that we call it the word of God? That we call it the very commands of God, handed down from him to us so that we can live the way he has designed us to live — if it was written by men?

4:13 How do we know that when Matthew recorded the words of Jesus, he actually recorded the words of Jesus? I mean, I probably wouldn't get it right. I was listening to our sermon just on Sunday, and I tried to write down exactly what the pastor said, because I really liked what he said in one particular sentence — and I couldn't remember exactly what he said in that moment. How could we expect Matthew to write down everything that Jesus said perfectly? These are the kinds of objections that you will get from your students.

4:47 And it's not a terribly difficult objection to deal with, but just to kind of paint the picture for you, the way I've done it with students in the past is this: think of it this way. I'm not making an exact equation, but it helps paint a better picture. You have Jesus, and you have the Bible. Now, clearly we don't treat the Bible the same way we treat Jesus. However, we very easily say that Jesus is 100% man and he's also 100% God. Now wait a minute — if I can comfortably say that, why can't I comfortably say that the Bible was written by men, inspired by God, to be completely accurate? See, if God can make this sort of thing happen, God can make this sort of thing happen. It's pretty simple.

5:43 The second objection you'll often hear students make is that the Bible may be accurate and historical and all of those things, but that the Bible is simply a book about God — that it's man's recordings of who God is, or of who they thought him to be. Now, that's not accurate either, because if the Bible is authoritative, then sure, it's what we think about God, but it was completely accurate about who God actually is. Because otherwise we don't know who God really is. But we do know who God really is, because he came in Jesus, so we actually do have that picture. So this is so your students start to see that, although it seems very easy to say other things about the Bible — things which really just allow us to excuse ourselves on various types of sin — what the Bible teaches is 100% authoritative.

In your small groups

6:40 So in your small groups, as you're thinking through all these things, think through the implications of what all of this means. These last four weeks, what is all of this coming to? What conclusions are your students now coming to? And I want you to remember three specific things that your students can understand in order to know truth through all of this.

One, they should have a greater appreciation for this, right? So if nothing else, they should have a greater appreciation for the Bible — what it says, what it teaches, how it came together, all of those pieces — and hopefully that will compel them to read a little bit more.

7:16 Secondly, that they'll be more inclined to read this. How many Christians have read the Bible cover to cover multiple times? It's the greatest book, the greatest, biggest-selling, best-selling book in the history of the world, and probably the least read book in the history of the world. And I think they're more likely to follow. The more they appreciate, the more they'll read; the better they'll follow. That is the aim of this week.

Into everyday conversation

7:47 Now, this has to sort of cross into — we're going to start talking in the next few weeks here about what this means in conversation. When your students are in college, when your students are talking with friends, and they might be sitting reading this and someone makes a comment: how do they then defend and talk intelligently about this biblical text? And I think over the last four weeks we've been able to provide the tools that our students need to be able to talk intelligently about what this book is all about.